Newton's laws of motion

Subject: Physics | Level: Class 9 | Curriculum: Federal Board
Prepared by: SHS Virtual Academy

1. Topic Overview and Learning Objectives

Newton's laws of motion form the bedrock of classical mechanics and are the most fundamental concepts you will encounter in your Class 9 Physics curriculum. These three laws describe the relationship between a body, the forces acting upon it, and its resulting motion. Understanding these principles is not just about memorizing definitions; it is about developing the intuition to see how every object in our daily life, from a moving car to a stationary book, obeys these universal rules of nature.

In the context of the Federal Board examinations, this chapter is of paramount importance. You will frequently encounter both conceptual questions and numerical problems based on these laws. Examiners often test your ability to apply these laws to real-world scenarios, such as explaining why passengers jerk forward when a bus stops suddenly or calculating the acceleration of a body under the influence of unbalanced forces. A firm grasp of these laws will provide you with the confidence to tackle a significant portion of your mechanics section.

The fundamental intuition behind these laws is the concept of inertia and the interaction between forces. Newton's First Law teaches us about the natural state of rest or uniform motion, the Second Law provides a quantitative bridge between force, mass, and acceleration, and the Third Law highlights the symmetry of interactions. By mastering these, you are not just preparing for an exam; you are learning the language that describes how the physical universe functions, which is the very essence of studying physics.

2. Core Concepts and Detailed Revision Notes

2.1 Newton's First Law of Motion: The Law of Inertia

Newton's First Law states that a body continues its state of rest or of uniform motion in a straight line provided that no net force acts on it. This law introduces the concept of inertia, which is the property of matter by virtue of which it resists any change in its state of rest or uniform motion. Think of it as the inherent tendency of matter; an object at rest wants to stay at rest, and an object in motion wants to keep moving at the same speed in the same direction. In the absence of an external unbalanced force, like friction or air resistance, an object would theoretically continue its motion forever. This law is essential for understanding that force is required not just to move an object, but to change its state of motion or direction.

Key Points to Remember:

1. A body at rest remains at rest unless acted upon by a net force.
2. A body in motion continues in a straight line at constant velocity unless acted upon by a net force.
3. Inertia is directly proportional to the mass of the object.
4. The first law is also known as the Law of Inertia.
5. Net force is the vector sum of all forces acting on a body.

2.2 Newton's Second Law of Motion: Force and Acceleration

Newton's Second Law provides the quantitative relationship between force, mass, and acceleration. It states that when a net force acts on a body, it produces acceleration in the direction of the force. The magnitude of this acceleration is directly proportional to the net force acting on the body and inversely proportional to its mass. Mathematically, this is expressed as F = m - a. This law is incredibly powerful because it allows us to calculate exactly how an object will respond to a push or a pull. If you apply a larger force, the acceleration increases; if you increase the mass of the object, the acceleration decreases for the same amount of force. This relationship is the basis for solving almost all numerical problems involving dynamics in your physics course.

Key Points to Remember:

1. Acceleration is directly proportional to the applied net force.
2. Acceleration is inversely proportional to the mass of the body.
3. The direction of acceleration is always the same as the direction of the net force.
4. The SI unit of force is the Newton (N), where 1 N = 1 kg m/s^2.
5. The formula is F = m - a, where F is force, m is mass, and a is acceleration.

2.3 Newton's Third Law of Motion: Action and Reaction

Newton's Third Law states that to every action, there is always an equal but opposite reaction. This means that forces never exist in isolation; they always occur in pairs. When object A exerts a force on object B, object B simultaneously exerts a force of equal magnitude but opposite direction on object A. It is important to remember that these two forces act on different bodies, which is why they do not cancel each other out. For example, when you walk, your foot pushes the ground backward, and the ground pushes your foot forward. This interaction is what allows us to move. Understanding this law helps clarify many phenomena, such as how rockets launch into space by expelling gas downward and receiving an upward reaction force.

Key Points to Remember:

1. Action and reaction forces are always equal in magnitude.
2. Action and reaction forces are always opposite in direction.
3. These forces act on two different bodies simultaneously.
4. The law explains how motion is possible through interaction.
5. There is no such thing as an isolated force in the universe.

2.4 Momentum and the Law of Conservation of Momentum

Momentum is defined as the quantity of motion possessed by a body, calculated as the product of its mass and velocity. It is a vector quantity, meaning it has both magnitude and direction. The Law of Conservation of Momentum states that the total momentum of an isolated system remains constant. This means that if two objects collide, the sum of their momenta before the collision is equal to the sum of their momenta after the collision, provided no external force acts on the system. This principle is vital for analyzing collisions, explosions, and the recoil of guns. By applying this law, we can predict the final velocities of objects after they interact, which is a common and important type of problem in your board examinations.

Key Points to Remember:

1. Momentum (p) = mass (m) - velocity (v).
2. The SI unit of momentum is kg m/s.
3. An isolated system is one where no external force acts.
4. Total initial momentum equals total final momentum in an isolated system.
5. Momentum is a vector quantity.

3. Key Definitions, Formulas, and Rules

1. **Newton's Second Law:** F = m - a
2. **Momentum:** p = m - v
3. **Weight:** w = m - g
4. **Force in terms of momentum:** F = Delta p / Delta t
5. **Conservation of Momentum:** m1-u1 + m2-u2 = m1-v1 + m2-v2
6. **Inertia:** The property of a body to resist any change in its state of rest or motion.
7. **Newton:** The force that produces an acceleration of 1 m/s^2 in a body of mass 1 kg.
8. **Impulse:** J = F - t = Delta p

4. Step-by-Step Worked Examples

Example 1: Calculating Force

Problem: A car of mass 1000 kg is moving with a velocity of 20 m/s. If it comes to rest in 5 seconds, what is the braking force applied?

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Identify given values: m = 1000 kg, initial velocity u = 20 m/s, final velocity v = 0 m/s, time t = 5 s.

Step 2: Calculate acceleration: a = (v - u) / t = (0 - 20) / 5 = -4 m/s^2.

Step 3: Apply Newton's Second Law: F = m - a = 1000 - (-4) = -4000 N.

Final Answer: -4000 N (The negative sign indicates the force is acting against the direction of motion).

Example 2: Momentum Calculation

Problem: What is the momentum of a 500 g ball moving at 10 m/s?

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Convert mass to SI units: m = 500 g = 0.5 kg.

Step 2: Identify velocity: v = 10 m/s.

Step 3: Use momentum formula: p = m - v = 0.5 - 10 = 5 kg m/s.

Final Answer: 5 kg m/s

Example 3: Conservation of Momentum

Problem: A 2 kg mass moving at 3 m/s hits a stationary 1 kg mass. If they stick together, what is their common velocity?

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Initial momentum: (2 - 3) + (1 - 0) = 6 kg m/s.

Step 2: Final momentum: (m1 + m2) - v = (2 + 1) - v = 3 - v.

Step 3: Equate: 6 = 3 - v.

Step 4: Solve for v: v = 6 / 3 = 2 m/s.

Final Answer: 2 m/s

Example 4: Weight Calculation

Problem: Find the weight of an object with a mass of 10 kg on Earth (g = 10 m/s^2).

Solution Steps:

Step 1: Identify mass: m = 10 kg.

Step 2: Identify gravity: g = 10 m/s^2.

Step 3: Use weight formula: w = m - g = 10 - 10 = 100 N.

Final Answer: 100 N

5. Common Exam Mistakes to Avoid

1. Confusing mass with weight: Remember that mass is constant while weight depends on gravity.
2. Forgetting to convert units: Always ensure mass is in kg and time is in seconds before using formulas.
3. Assuming action and reaction forces cancel: Always remember they act on different objects.
4. Ignoring the negative sign in deceleration: If an object slows down, acceleration must be negative.
5. Misapplying the conservation of momentum: Ensure the system is isolated and no external forces are considered.
6. Forgetting vector directions: Momentum and force are vectors, so direction matters in your calculations.

6. Practice Questions and Model Answers

Question 1

Define inertia and explain how it relates to mass.

Answer 1: Inertia is the inherent property of a body to resist changes in its state of rest or uniform motion. It is directly related to mass; the greater the mass of an object, the greater its inertia, meaning it is harder to change its state of motion.

Question 2

Why does a passenger move forward when a bus stops suddenly?

Answer 2: Due to inertia, the lower part of the passenger's body comes to rest with the bus, but the upper part continues to move forward at the original speed, causing the passenger to jerk forward.

Question 3

A force of 20 N acts on a 5 kg mass. Calculate the acceleration.

Answer 3: Using F = m - a, we get 20 = 5 - a. Therefore, a = 20 / 5 = 4 m/s^2.

Question 4

State the Law of Conservation of Momentum.

Answer 4: The total momentum of an isolated system remains constant. In any collision, the sum of momenta before the collision equals the sum of momenta after the collision.

Question 5

Can action and reaction forces cancel each other? Why or why not?

Answer 5: No, they cannot cancel each other because they act on two different bodies. For forces to cancel, they must act on the same body.